



FOOD FOR THOUGHT

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Debunking protein myths

Here's everything you need to know about protein supplementation, so you can make choices that **truly benefit your health.**

As a nutritionist, I've had the privilege of working with a wide range of clients — from athletes to weekend warriors and anyone just looking to feel healthier and stronger. And let me tell you — one question never fails to come up: what's the real deal with protein?

You've probably heard all kinds of myths floating around about protein supplements: "Do I really need them?" "Won't they make me bulky?" "Are they safe in the long run?" The confusion is real, and the truth often gets lost in the noise. So, let's cut through the clutter together.

In this article, I'm diving into the science, the myths, and everything you need to know about protein supplementation, so you can make choices that truly benefit your health and goals. Ready to clear up the confusion? Let's jump right into it.

Myth#1: High-protein diets are bad for kidney health

One of the most persistent myths I encounter is the idea that high-protein diets are bad for kidney health. Many believe that protein places excessive strain on the kidneys, but research has shown that for healthy individuals with no pre-existing kidney conditions, this simply isn't the case. The body can handle high protein intake just fine, especially within the recommended range of 1.2–2.0 grams per kilogram of body weight. For those with kidney issues, a lower protein intake might be advised, but for the majority of us, there's no need to worry about kidney damage.

Myth#2: Protein leads to fat gain

Another misconception is that excess protein automatically leads to fat gain. This idea often stems from the belief that protein is stored as fat when you eat too much. The truth is that any excess calories — whether from protein, carbohydrates, or fat — can contribute to weight gain if you consume more than your body needs. However, protein has a unique benefit: it

helps preserve lean muscle mass, especially during weight loss, leading to better body composition. So, protein itself isn't the problem; it's excess calories in general.

Myth#3: Plant-based diets can't provide enough protein

For those following plant-based diets, there's often concern about whether they can consume enough protein to support muscle growth and training. While plant proteins might not contain as much of certain essential amino acids as animal-based proteins, the key is variety. Research shows that vegans and vegetarians can absolutely meet their protein needs by eating a variety of plant-based foods like soy, beans, lentils, and other legumes. In fact, vegans and vegetarians may need to consume slightly more protein than those who eat animal products to meet their amino acid requirements, but with proper planning, it's very achievable.

Myth#4: Cheese and peanut butter are good protein sources

When it comes to foods like cheese and peanut butter, while they do provide some protein, they're also high in fat and shouldn't be relied upon as primary protein sources, especially if you're looking to increase protein intake without adding extra calories from fat.